

Halgic Research Integration Series

ALABAMA-COUSHATTA

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

The People of the Piney Woods -- Two Nations, One People, Surviving in the Big Thicket

Istissi hachi.

We are still here.

The fire has not gone out.

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Community Respect

The Alabama-Coushatta Tribe of Texas has maintained many aspects of their sacred tradition as community-held knowledge not intended for public dissemination. This document presents what tribal members and cultural representatives have shared in public contexts -- the ceremonial structure and purposes, the cosmological framework, and the cultural heritage. Specific prayers, specific sacred songs, and the most restricted ceremonial content are not included here. The Alabama-Coushatta people are a living community, and this document is written in the spirit of honoring their survival, not extracting their secrets.

Introduction -- Two Nations Who Became One People

The Alabama-Coushatta Tribe of Texas -- the only federally recognized Native American tribe in East Texas -- represents the sustained survival of two closely related Muskogean-speaking nations who, through more than a century of displacement from their original Southeastern homelands, found a permanent home in the dense pine forests of what is now Polk County, Texas. Today, approximately 1,100 tribal members maintain a reservation of approximately 4,600 acres in the Big Thicket region -- the extraordinarily biodiverse forested landscape that provided refuge when no other space remained.

The Alabama (Alibamu -- "vegetation gatherers" or "those who clear land") originally inhabited the territory of present-day central Alabama, along the Alabama River. The Coushatta (Koasati -- possibly "white cane" or "reed place") lived to the north and west, along the Coosa and Tennessee Rivers. Both peoples are members of the broader Muskogean family -- the same linguistic and cultural group as the Creek, Choctaw, and Chickasaw nations -- and shared closely related languages, clan systems, sacred ceremonies, and cosmological frameworks long before the westward migration that would eventually bring them to Texas.

The Long Walk West -- From Alabama to Texas

The Alabama-Coushatta path from their Southeastern homelands to East Texas was not a single forced march but a generational process spanning approximately 1700 to 1850 -- a series of progressive westward movements driven by colonial pressure, encroachment on their lands, and the specific violence of American expansion. At each stage, the communities carried their sacred traditions -- the ceremonial fire, the Green Corn Ceremony, the ball game, the clan system, the language.

Late 1700s -- Louisiana: Some Alabama and Coushatta bands moved into Louisiana, establishing communities along the Red River. Spanish colonial authorities were generally more tolerant than American authorities. Early 1800s -- East Texas: Further movement westward brought both nations into East Texas -- then under Spanish and then Mexican authority. The Big Thicket region offered dense forest providing both protection and the specific plants needed for medicine and material culture. Sam Houston, who had lived among the Cherokee, provided some protection and advocated for their land rights. The current reservation was set aside in 1854 by the State of Texas -- making the Alabama-Coushatta the only Native American group with a land reservation established by the State of Texas before federal recognition. Federal recognition came in 1928. Full federal status was restored in 1987 after the termination threats of the 1950s.

The Clan System -- Foundation of Social and Sacred Life

Like all Muskogean-speaking peoples, the Alabama and Coushatta organized their social life through a matrilineal clan system -- identity, obligation, marriage rules, and specific

ceremonial responsibilities all determined by the mother's clan. The clan system provided the specific social structure through which the community maintained cohesion across generations of displacement; it was one of the primary mechanisms through which Alabama-Coushatta identity survived the pressures of colonial contact.

The Wind Clan (Thlocco): Associated with leadership -- chiefs and major political figures traditionally came from the Wind Clan. Its connection to the sky and to the directional forces gave it specific sacred authority. The Bear Clan: Associated with medicine and healing -- the practitioners of traditional medicine were often from the Bear Clan. The bear is understood to have specific knowledge of medicinal plants because it eats them during illness. The Deer Clan: Associated with the forest, with hunting protocols, and the specific relationship between humans and the deer nation -- maintaining the sacred knowledge of proper hunting conduct and the ceremonies that honored the deer for the gift of its body. Marriage within one's own clan was strictly prohibited -- clans were understood as extended family, and intra-clan marriage was incest regardless of actual biological relationship.

The Creator and the Three-World Sacred Cosmology

Alabama-Coushatta sacred cosmology understands the universe as organized into three vertically stacked realms -- the Above World (the sky and celestial domain, home of the Creator and sacred beings), the This World (the earth surface where human life takes place), and the Below World (the underworld, associated with water and with specific sacred and dangerous powers). This three-world structure is shared across Muskogean and broader Southeastern Indigenous cosmologies and organizes the specific understanding of what ceremony is doing: maintaining right relationship between all three realms simultaneously.

The Creator (called Abba Chokoli -- "the One Above" in Alabama) is the supreme sacred power who established the world and the proper relationships within it. The Green Corn Ceremony and the Sacred Fire are the primary technologies through which the community maintains its relationship with Abba Chokoli -- the new fire kindled from friction is understood as the Creator's presence renewed in the community, the corn given by the Creator acknowledged and celebrated before it is consumed.

The Below World is associated with water, with serpentine powers, and with specific dangerous forces that must be respected rather than ignored. The black drink ceremony that opens the Green Corn Ceremony is specifically connected to purification -- expelling the accumulated contact with Below World influences that every human being accumulates through ordinary life. The scratching ceremony serves a similar purpose: making the body permeable to release what has accumulated, preparing it for the renewed relationship with the Above World that the ceremony establishes.

HALIGRIC LENS: The three-world cosmology is the Southeastern expression of the vertical sacred structure found in Lithuanian tradition (Pasaulio Medis connecting the three realms), in Ojibwe tradition (the sky beings above, the Underwater Panther below, the living world between), and in Mandaean tradition (the World of Light above, the World of Darkness below, the human soul suspended between). The specific technologies differ. The understanding is the same: the human community lives at the intersection of sacred forces that flow both from above and from below, and the ceremonies that maintain right relationship must address both directions simultaneously.

The Sacred Fire -- The Central Ceremonial Presence

The sacred fire (the central fire of the ceremonial ground -- the talwa or town square ground) is the most important physical sacred presence in Alabama-Coushatta ceremonial life -- the living representative of the Creator's presence in the community, the center around which all ceremony moves, and the specific continuity that connects the contemporary community to their ancestral homeland. When the Alabama and Coushatta

moved westward, they carried fire from their original ceremonial grounds -- the continuity of the sacred fire was the continuity of the community's sacred identity.

The ceremonial fire is not merely a fire -- it is a sacred being, a direct manifestation of the Creator's presence. Speaking to the fire, making offerings to the fire, and maintaining the fire in its proper state are acts of ongoing relationship with the sacred. During ceremonial events, specific protocols govern who may tend the fire, how it may be tended, and what may or may not happen near it. Prayer offered at the sacred fire is prayer spoken directly to the Creator -- the fire is the medium through which the community's intentions, gratitude, and needs reach the divine.

The Medicine Tradition -- Healers, Plants, and Wellness

The Alabama-Coushatta medicine tradition is one of the most extensive plant-based healing systems documented among Southeastern Native American peoples. Over 60 to 70 medicinal plants native to the Big Thicket have been documented in Alabama-Coushatta ethnobotanical knowledge -- a sophisticated system built over centuries of observation, transmitted through specific apprenticeship to designated medicine keepers, and organized around the same cosmological framework that governs all the tradition's sacred practice.

The medicine tradition distinguishes between physical ailments addressed through specific plant preparations and spiritual imbalances addressed through ceremony. Both are understood as dimensions of the same underlying reality: health is the condition of right relationship between the person, their community, and the sacred world. A person who is physically ill may also be spiritually out of alignment; a person who is spiritually disturbed may manifest that disturbance in the body.

Key documented medicines from the Big Thicket: Yaupon holly (*Ilex vomitoria* -- the source of the black drink used in the Green Corn Ceremony) was the primary purification medicine. Sassafras was used to make teas for fever treatment. Strawberry Bush (*Hearts a Bustin with Love*) was used in teas given to women during childbirth to ease pain. Longleaf pine resin served as adhesive and had medicinal applications. River cane (*Arundinaria gigantea*) was used not only in material culture (baskets, blowgun darts) but in specific medicinal preparations. The Alabama tribal name itself -- "vegetation gatherers" -- reflects how central plant knowledge was to the people's identity. Over 196 plant species have been documented in Alabama-Coushatta nomenclature for utility.

Contemporary wellness at Alabama-Coushatta: The tribe partners with the Nature Conservancy on prescribed fire management of the reservation's longleaf pine forest -- an explicitly sacred act as well as an ecological one. Longleaf pine has shaped Alabama-Coushatta material culture, housing, medicine, and ceremonial life for centuries. Restoring the longleaf through controlled fire is understood as restoring the sacred relationship with the specific landscape that sheltered the people when no other place remained. The tradition of using fire to tend the land -- a practice suppressed under American land management policies for nearly a century -- is being restored alongside the ceremonies that the land sustained.

The Green Corn Ceremony (Poskita) -- Step-by-Step

The Green Corn Ceremony (Poskita -- from the Muskogean word for "fasting") is the central sacred ceremony of the Alabama-Coushatta -- the annual ceremony of renewal, purification, forgiveness, and thanksgiving held when the corn reaches the stage of ripeness called "green corn" (in late summer, typically July or August). It is simultaneously the new year ceremony, the forgiveness ceremony, the first-fruits ceremony, and the most complete expression of the Alabama-Coushatta's relationship with the sacred.

Preparation (Weeks Before): The ceremonial ground is cleaned and prepared. Buildings are repaired. Participants fast for specific periods. Sacred medicines are gathered and prepared by the medicine keepers. The specific positions for each clan's participation are established.

Step 1 -- Opening: The ceremonial leaders formally open the sacred ground, acknowledging the Creator and the sacred fire.

Step 2 -- The Black Drink (Asi): The ceremony opens with the ritual consumption of the black drink -- a highly caffeinated tea brewed from the leaves of yaupon holly (*Ilex vomitoria*), which in sufficient quantity induces vomiting. This purging is the physical enactment of the ceremony's purification purpose -- expelling what has accumulated in the body over the past year. Consumed communally with specific protocol governing who drinks and in what order.

Step 3 -- Scratching: Specific clan members receive ritual scratching -- small scratches made with a comb-like implement on the arms and legs. The scratching releases accumulated negative energies from the body.

Step 4 -- Extinguishing the Old Fire: The sacred fire is formally extinguished -- the accumulated contamination of the previous year goes out with it.

Step 5 -- The New Fire: New fire is kindled through friction -- specific wood, specific technique, specific prayers. The new fire is the new year's beginning, the community's renewal at the deepest sacred level.

Step 6 -- The First Corn: The new corn -- which was forbidden to eat until the ceremony -- is formally presented to the sacred fire. The first consumption of new corn happens in ceremony with specific prayers and protocols.

Step 7 -- The Stomp Dance: The community dances around the sacred fire -- the stomp dance's counterclockwise movement, the shell-shaker women's rhythm, and the call-and-response between leader and group are the primary ceremonial expression of collective joy and renewal.

Step 8 -- The Forgiveness: The Green Corn Ceremony includes a specific moment of communal forgiveness -- grievances and wrongs of the past year that have not been formally resolved are released. No one enters the new year still holding last year's wounds.

Step 9 -- The Feast: The ceremonial feast -- featuring the new corn along with other community foods -- celebrates the renewal and expresses gratitude to the Creator for the year's sustenance.

Step 10 -- Distribution of New Fire: Every household receives new fire from the sacred center -- the community's individual domestic fires renewed from the one sacred source, expressing the unity of the community under the Creator's care.

The Sacred Ball Game (Toli) -- Ceremony as Athletic Contest

The traditional ball game (called *toli* or *kapocca* -- related to the game known as stickball, lacrosse's predecessor) is one of the most important ceremonial practices of the Southeastern peoples and one of the most distinctive expressions of the Alabama-Coushatta's ceremonial life. It is emphatically not simply a sport -- it is a ceremony in which physical competition serves sacred purposes, and in which the preparation and protocol surrounding the game are as important as the game itself.

The ball game is played with one or two sticks (each approximately two feet long, with a small net at one end) and a small ball. Historically played between entire communities with the field sometimes stretching for miles. The ball game has been called "the little brother of war" -- it served as a substitute for armed conflict between communities, resolved disputes

that might otherwise require violence, and tested the collective spiritual and physical power of the community.

The night before a major ball game was spent in ceremony -- dancing, prayer, and the application of specific sacred medicines. Players observed specific restrictions: specific foods were avoided, specific behaviors were prohibited. The medicine practitioners sang specific songs over the players and their ball sticks. Women did not play in the game but participated in specific ceremonial roles. The Alabama-Coushatta have maintained the stickball tradition and continue to play ceremonial games at specific community events -- a remarkable survival given that the game was suppressed by American authorities as part of the broader suppression of Native American cultural practices.

The Stomp Dance -- Sacred Movement and Community, Step-by-Step

The Stomp Dance is one of the most widespread sacred ceremonial forms in the Southeastern Indigenous world -- practiced by the Alabama-Coushatta, the Creek, the Cherokee, the Seminole, the Yuchi, and related nations -- and one of the most immediately accessible expressions of the tradition's understanding of sacred movement as community-building and Creator-honoring practice.

Step 1 -- The Call: The lead singer begins with specific calls that open the dance -- distinctive rising vocal patterns that signal the beginning of a new song set, answered by the male dancers.

Step 2 -- The Formation: Dancers form a line or circle with the lead singer at the front. The pattern moves counterclockwise around the sacred fire -- counterclockwise is the sacred direction in Southeastern ceremonial movement, following the movement of the sun from the perspective of facing south.

Step 3 -- The Shell Shakers: Women wearing leg rattles -- traditionally turtle shells filled with pebbles, now often condensed milk cans filled with small stones, worn on the lower legs -- provide the primary rhythmic foundation. The shell shaker's role is sacred and skilled: maintaining precise rhythm throughout the night requires both physical endurance and ceremonial preparation.

Step 4 -- The Call and Response: The lead singer calls specific phrases; the male dancers respond. Specific songs for specific occasions, specific songs to invite specific sacred qualities. The call and response structure means the entire community's voices are engaged together.

Step 5 -- Progression Through the Night: The Stomp Dance typically continues through much or all of the night -- beginning at dark and continuing until the rise of the day. Different song sets have different characters; the dance progresses through a specific sequence of increasing and decreasing intensity.

Step 6 -- The Breaks: At specific intervals, the dance breaks -- water may be passed, tobacco may be smoked. The breaks are part of the ceremony's rhythm.

Step 7 -- The Closing: The dance formally closes when the lead singer performs specific closing sequences -- signaling to the community and to the spirit world that this particular ceremony is complete.

Language, Gaming Rights, and Contemporary Sovereignty

The Alabama language (Alibamu) and the Coushatta language (Koasati) are both Muskogean languages closely related to Creek. Both have been the subject of active revitalization efforts. The Coushatta language in particular has a documented revitalization program, as Koasati is spoken by a small number of fluent speakers; the Alabama-Coushatta Tribe of

Texas and the Coushatta Tribe of Louisiana both maintain language preservation programs. The languages carry the specific sacred vocabulary -- the names for the ceremonies, for the sacred beings, for the clans, for the plants and their uses -- that the tradition depends on.

The Alabama-Coushatta Tribe of Texas opened the "Living Indian Village" tourist operation on their reservation in the mid-20th century as an economic development strategy -- one of the early examples of Native American cultural tourism in Texas. The tribe also established gaming operations after the Indian Gaming Regulatory Act (1988), which provided significant economic resources for tribal programs. The Gaming Commission managing the tribal enterprise has enabled investments in language preservation, cultural education, and land management that were not previously possible.

The partnership with the Nature Conservancy to restore longleaf pine through prescribed fire is the most visible contemporary expression of the tribe's sacred relationship with the Big Thicket landscape -- the same fire that centers their ceremonies, that renews their year at the Green Corn, that they carried across two hundred years of westward displacement, is being used to restore the specific forest ecosystem that their tradition and their survival are built on.

The Haligricity Lens -- The Sacred Fire and Right Relationship

The Alabama-Coushatta tradition offers Haligricity the most complete available Southeastern Indigenous model of the sacred fire as the living center of community life -- not as symbol or metaphor but as the specific physical presence of the Creator's sustaining attention. Every ceremony orbits the fire. Every household receives fire from the sacred center. The new year begins when the old fire goes out and the new fire is kindled from the friction of specific wood.

The Green Corn Ceremony's built-in forgiveness practice -- the specific ceremonial moment when last year's accumulated grievances are released before the new year begins -- is the most institutionally complete available expression of what the Haligric tradition holds about clearing: you cannot carry last year's unresolved weight into the new year's work without dragging that weight into everything you build. The Alabama-Coushatta found the ceremonial technology to prevent this accumulation -- and they maintained it through two hundred years of displacement, pressure, and cultural suppression.

They walked from Alabama through Mississippi through Louisiana into East Texas and they did not put down the fire. Not once in two hundred years of walking did they let it go out -- not the ceremonial fire's continuity, not the Green Corn's forgiveness, not the clan system's kinship web, not the language that held the sacred names. The Big Thicket held them when nowhere else would. They are still there. The Stomp Dance moves counterclockwise around the sacred fire in Polk County, Texas, every year. Grand Rising.